Conservatorium Maastricht, Zuyd Hogeschool

Advanced Teaching Skills

Final Thesis

Piano Sight-reading in Musical Education

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1. Introduction

I´m a classical pianist currently studying at the Conservatorium Maastricht. I decided to write my final thesis about piano sight-reading because my personal experience with this subject was rather negative. As a child, I followed a piano education in a music school. Later, I studied at a music-specialized high school in Prague, the capital of the Czech Republic. During my studies, I have never come across a full-fledged sight-reading education and it was not even included in regular piano lessons. According to what I have experienced, the prior focus during the teaching procedure is usually placed on playing by heart, memorizing musical text, and performing a piece without mistakes. However, sight-reading is certainly of the same importance. This thesis *"Piano Sight-reading in Musical Education"* aims to explain why. To introduce the topic deeper, I will present the basis of the sight-reading process and explicate which subskills are included in it. I will expound on how could be sight-reading salutary for student´s musical development and discuss reasons why most educational institutions lack this subject. A spacious part of this thesis is devoted to tips and practical exercises for beginners and advanced sight-readers. Further is the emphasis placed on the analysis of the study book for piano sight-reading *"Improve Your Sight-reading"* by British author Paul Harris. I focus on relevant segments of his approach and justify why using this book in a general piano lesson might be beneficial. At last, I propound a list of sight-reading online tools that are designed in a creative and helpful way and head to facilitate sight-reading education.

2. Vision on teaching

As a piano teacher, I want to provide a musical education in a larger context. I believe that the various musical skills of a student should be developed equally from the very beginning. That applies also to sight-reading. I would like to help students get familiar with the "seeing-doing" process, which is so special about sight-reading, and avoid a later resistance to learning such a thing. The sooner student gets in touch with this process, the faster it becomes a natural ability. It is important to adjust the level of the score to the experience of the student. A great collection of specialized exercises offers study-book series for piano sight-reading *"Improve your Sight Reading"* by Paul Harris. There can every teacher find exercises for musicians of all levels, from beginners to professional pianists. In my lessons, I would like to use this book since I believe it is a good tool to make sight-reading attractive. The general layout is very well organized and contains melodic musical examples that are pleasant to hear. The author presents advice and tips that help students to simplify the whole process. That also works perfectly during home preparation because students have clear guidance to follow.

To include sight-reading in a general piano lesson, I would like to create an individual routine with each student. The moment to read a score could be placed at the beginning of the lesson as a warm-up. And as a well-deserved "reward" it could work perfectly at the end of the lesson as well. This is something, that needs to be decided individually. To make the

repertoire even more interesting, I would also use varied material such as folk songs or four-hand piano pieces. Motivation is at the end a crucial point of the learning progress.

My intention is to popularize this topic with a wider community of musicians, especially in countries, where it is needed. In the future, I would like to participate in this change as a teacher. To my students, I will present the sight-reading as an important and joyful part of their future carrier.

3. Research Question

1. How could be sight-reading involved in a general piano lesson?

Sub-questions:

1. **How does piano sight-reading positively contribute to the musical development of a student?**
2. **Which tips and exercises help us to sight-read faster and more effectively?**
3. **Why is it beneficial for students to follow a study book for piano sight-reading?**

4. Method

To find answers to my research question and its sub-questions, I will go through literal resources to find more detailed information about the topic. I will focus on scholarly theses and articles about sight-reading theory and dive into problems of reading from score deeply. I would like to compare different points of view and also share my own experience. Source of a big inspiration for me is the thesis *"Van Blad spelen voor Pianisten" ("Reading from score for pianists")* by Jeroen Riemsdijk. I would especially appropriate to mention the practical exercises that Jeroen indicates there. Besides theoretical material, I will also draw information from educational YouTube videos and other relevant online content.

5. Research

5.1 How does piano sight-reading positively contribute to the musical development of a student?

1. Introduction to Sight-reading

Sight-reading is an essential skill for every pianist. Being a good sight-reader is valuable not only for personal musical development but also for various career opportunities. Pianists are often asked to accompany auditions or to take on the role of a co-repetiteur in an opera house or conservatory. Also, for teaching is playing from the sheet very useful, since the teacher should be able to reproduce pieces of his students quickly and accurately. Explaining a certain topic - phrasing, dynamic, or a technical issue - while showing it on the keyboard is a common approach. In short, playing at first sight is an ability to perform a sufficient quality without previous preparation.

"Sight-reading is not a unitary skill but should rather be regarded as a collection of subskills that can be discussed and studied separately" (Lehmann, 2002, p.138). To understand better the complexity of sight-reading, I would like to present its key aspects:

- **essential reading** (recognizing notes, intervals)
- **additional reading** (dynamic, expression marks)
- **knowledge of advanced rhythms**
- **instant knowledge of harmony**
- **elementary and advanced techniques** (mastering elementary techniques like scales, arpeggios, leaps without looking at the keyboard)
- **reading the score a few bars ahead**

How fast a student combines those aspects, determines his level of reading the score. Speed is usually an issue for most musicians. They often lack the connection between understanding the text and immediately producing what is written. This could be improved only by daily practice.

2. Musical development benefits

The ability to read the score contributes to a sufficient understanding of a musical text. Students, who have been taught sight-reading, naturally trained other for piano-playing desirable skills as well. They can analyse musical text quickly, understand its essential aspects, and create a better overview of the piece as a whole. They understand better the harmony since they learned it not only theoretically on a paper, but also practically during playing. That results in awareness of harmonic functions and their role in music (e.g. *V. – "Dominant"* brings tension in the music and tends to be resolved, *I. – "Tonic"* brings stability). Sight-readers have a better image of the keyboard topography. Therefore, it is easier for them to react on the spot, for example, to accompany a given melody or imitate another instrument. They also

often master technical elements like scales and arpeggios. Together with a good understanding of the rhythm and musical expression it leads to musical flexibility. I believe that music is like a language. And once we learn its structure and rules, we can freely express a lot. This opens the door also for improvisation and composing.

At last, students, who are used to sight-read, have less strain to learn a new repertoire. That could be very favourable for studies at the conservatory, where students have to manage a high number of pieces.

All those benefits must sound attractive to every student. Musical freedom and flexibility are in the end the most enjoyable parts of playing an instrument. Every student will develop comprehensively and gain more career opportunities in the future.

3. General problematic

In conformity with my own experience, students at music schools and conservatories are mainly trained of for long-term work. They focus on a difficult piece with all its details from the very beginning and aim to play it perfectly by heart. Sight-reading training is, unfortunately, usually eliminated. Teachers do not spend time taking care of this skill, although they declare it as an important one. *"In spite of the value placed on piano sight-reading by music educators, piano students are often deficient in the skill, creating a large gap between the reading level and the difficulty of performance pieces." (Hardy, 1992, p.12)*

What could prevent such a situation? Teachers have the potency to lead their students in the right direction. One of the first steps is to involve piano sight-reading in regular piano lessons. Unless there is a special curriculum for sight-reading as an independent subject. Unfortunately, that happens rarely. If we speak about children, it is necessary to acquaint them with sight-reading from the beginning of their education. Show them, that looking into the score is normal and teach them to rely not only on their eyes, but also on their hand "topography" on the keyboard.

5.2 What are the key steps to sight-read faster and effectively?

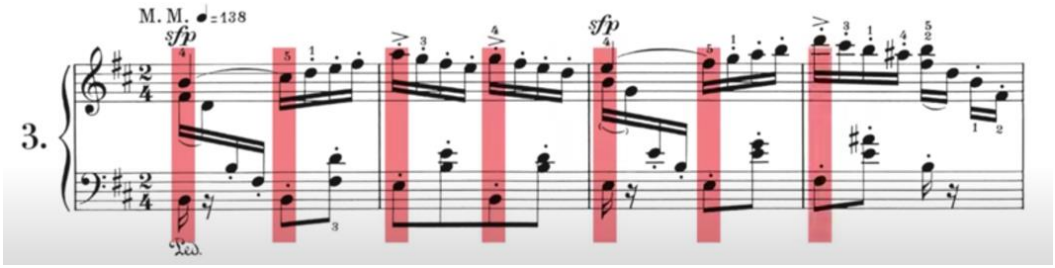
1. Tips for beginners to improve the sight-reading

It is good to amplify each aspect of sight-reading separately and afterwards combine them during the actual playing from score. During my research, I came across many good tips in literary sources or YouTube videos and would like to share those I have found the most relevant.

For beginners who are getting familiar with the notation, could be helpful various apps, for example, *"Note Rush"* or *"Interval test"*. The main purpose of *"Note Rush"* is to recognize the given note quickly and press it on the keyboard. *"Interval test"* offers several types of interval recognition: by hearing, by reading from the score, and by seeing it on the keyboard.

You proceed through different levels while the difficulty is increasing. This could be a useful tool for people who want to stay motivated and like to challenge themselves. It could help them to understand how intervals work since there is a detailed explanation in the app. The trick is to pay attention to the lines and spaces. If two notes are both on a line or both in the space, they create an odd number interval. If they are placed differently, they create an even number interval. After several rounds of the interval test in the app, the brain gets used to the simple task and starts to learn. Interval recognition then feels much easier by the actual sight-reading.

After getting through the notation, comes the next step: rhythm. It is essential to understand the time signature. The top number tells us how many beats there in a measure are, and the bottom number shows what type of note gets one count (a quarter note, a half note, an eight note, etc.) From that point, it is good to search for division points per bar (Pic.1). Focusing on strong beats could help us orientate better in the rhythmical speed and support our inner pulse.

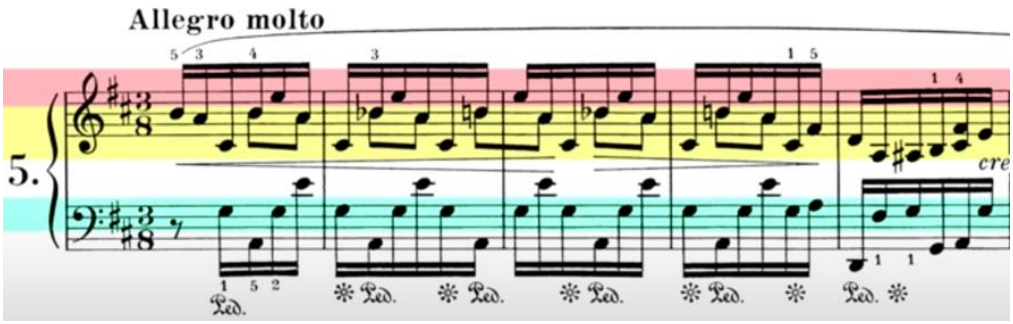


Pic.1

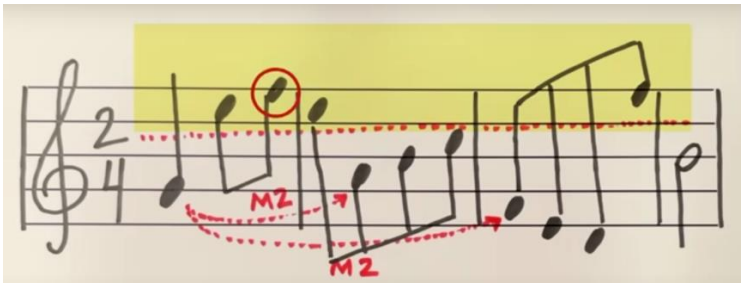
Another challenge is to play from score without looking at hands. Many beginners rely on their eyes and are used to control every movement on the keyboard. They often tend to switch between looking at their hands and at the score. Such a constant “task switching” leads to brain confusion. Our focus should be pointed mainly on the text. Breaking this habit needs extra time. It is helpful to cover the keyboard with a scarf or to practice in a complete dark. When is it no longer possible to see what we play our brain will learn to rely more on the touch. Moving hands more forward to the piano desk could make this training even more intense since then we feel the layout of black and white keys under the fingers. This skill could also be trained with repertoire, which we already know well. Closing our eyes while playing familiar pieces will help us deepen our muscle memory and improve the orientation on the keyboard as well.

2. Tricks for advanced sight-readers

Once the level of sight-reading advanced, it is time to explore tricks that make the orientation in the score even easier. There are many ways to understand the notation. One of them is called *“Tiering”.* We divide the musical text into several layers to avoid measuring large intervals (pic.2). We keep some notes in mind as reference notes of a certain pitch (pic.3). It means that we are dealing with, for example, two pitches within one hand. That sounds scary however, this point of view is more effective and faster than reading just single intervals.



Pic. 2



Pic.3

Another technic is called *"Clamping"*. Instead of reading note by note, it is better to look for larger groups of notes and familiar patterns in the music. Sufficient knowledge of scales, chords, keys, rhythmical patterns, key signatures, and elementary techniques obviously helps by *"Clamping"*. Although we do not identify an exact identity of each chord, it is still useful to be aware that this passage is build up from chords. Our hands than expect to play material of the same category. Besides that, it is much easier to determine the correct fingering, because we have a reference to something, we already know. Focusing on too many details has a negative impact on the speed and usually leads to hesitation. Therefore, searching for unifying elements within each musical section is so important.

Classical pianists are usually trained to reproduce the musical text with all its details. That is obvious for solo pieces that are performed at an examination or a concert. With sight-reading the situation is different. Learning to skip inessential details like trills, ornaments, or unimportant chord tones makes the performance much more fluent. Experienced sight-readers are able to imagine a harmonic and rhythmic skeleton that helps them decide on essential and additional aspects of the music. There are several rules to follow. It is necessary to maintain a rhythmical pulsation. That means we have to respect the alternation of strong and soft beats. Strong beats should be preferably played and emphasized. Another tip is to search for main harmonic functions like I., V., or IV. degree. Those are moments that need special attention since they influence the phrasing and general musical feeling. Within those borders could be the musical text adjusted and performed in a sufficient quality.

3. Practical exercises

When it comes to practice, the thesis *"Van Blad spelen voor Pianisten" ("Reading from score for pianists")* by Jeroen Riemsdijk offers many practical exercises and techniques to improve sight-reading. Jeroen presents sight-reading in its full complexity and explains

educational issues, he deals with as a piano teacher at Conservatorium Maastricht. *"What can be learned in fifteen minutes? What in an hour and what in a day? How quickly does someone think? How quickly can problems be recognized? How quickly can problems be solved? These and other questions are central to my lesson in sight-reading." (Riemsdijk, 2011, p.38)* Indeed, those questions help to define the starting point for future accomplishments. Jeroen perceives reading from score as a skill that could be more or less demanding for each student, depending on his background and experiences. *"Usually, it is clear in a few minutes where someone stands with his reading skills and how fast someone thinks musically." (Riemsdijk, 2011, p.38)* According to that, it is good to draw up an individual practice routine that could student follow in a free time. Everyone faces different issues. Sometimes it is insufficient knowledge of harmony, slow recognition of chords and intervals, or hand-coordination problems.

One of the bases is to get comfortable with five-finger patterns and the twelve-hand position on the keyboard. A good exercise is the chromatic shifting chords. We can start with, for example, triads in the root position and shift them always a half-tone up or down. To increase the intensity of this exercise, it is good to work with a metronome and speed up gradually up to 120 per chord. Then we are forced to think faster and shifting hand position becomes a natural habit. In the same way, we can use any five-finger piece or more complex chord, e.g., the seventh chord, and simply transpose it to the twelve-hand position.

Proper orientation on the keyboard is one of the conditions for reading fluently and with confidence. It depends on our inner visualization, awareness of interval distances, and knowledge of the keyboard layout. As I mentioned in previous paragraphs, covering the keyboard is one of the helpful tools. However, it is good to add a simple task, as Jeroen presents in his thesis. *"Play a chord in octave jumps, with one hand, with two hands, in the contrary motion." (Riemsdijk, 2011, p.41)* He again recommends working with a metronome and building up the speed step by step.

5.3 How could be sight-reading involved in a general piano lesson?

1. Difficulties with lack of time

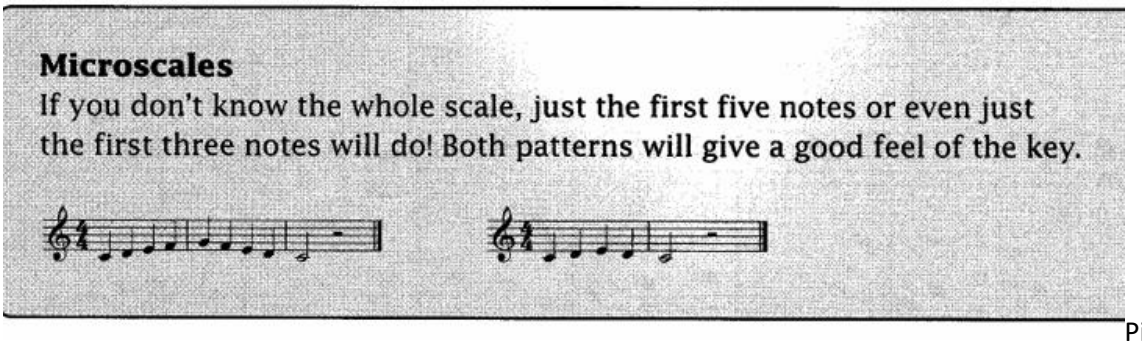
Involving sight-reading in a general piano lesson could be harder than it sounds. The main reason is simply a shortage of time. Once a student starts taking lessons in a music school or at the conservatory, the curriculum is usually quite intense and requires preparation of a wide repertoire including technical basics like scales or arpeggios. Most of the teachers obviously devote the majority of the lesson to pieces that are supposed to be evaluated in the exam. Therefore, creating a space for additional activities like sight-reading could be challenging. However, as I mentioned in the opening of this thesis, the sooner a student gets in touch with reading from a score, the faster it becomes a natural ability. Creating an individual routine with every student helps to organize the lesson wisely. Depending on preferences, sight-reading could be placed at the beginning of the lesson as a warm-up. Or it could perfectly work at the end as a well-deserved "reward". It does not have to take a lot of time. I am

convinced, that even 5 or 10 minutes of a guided sight-reading could be a great start. Then we can still keep the concert repertoire as a priority.

2. Study book for piano sight-reading

To start with a well-structured education, it is helpful to follow one of the study books for piano sight-reading. I had a good experience with the book *"Improve Your Sight-reading"* by a British pedagogue Paul Harris. Therefore, I would like to give a short overview of this method and explain, what I found relevant about Harris´s approach.

"Improve Your Sight-reading" is a series of nine books with the following titles: *Early Elementary, Elementary, Late Elementary, Early Intermediate, Intermediate, Late Intermediate, Early Advanced, and Advanced.* Each book is devoted to a different difficulty level and all tasks are gradually sorted. Rhythmical complicity, length, or the number of musical layers increases in given exercises. Every musical issue (e.g. new rhythmical value, chord, key) is introduced theoretically and also practically. Harris intends to practice each aspect individually. For example, to get familiar with a new key, he presents its accidentals, its mood and shows the scale and arpeggios. The following exercises are then composed only in that key. He recommends strongly always playing a scale and an arpeggio before each exercise. For those who don´t know the whole scale, he offers as an alternative reduced version *"Microscale"* (Pic.4). Like that can everyone get a good feel of the key. At the beginning of every chapter, Harris provides rhythmical and melodic exercises that are meant to prepare the student for actual sight-reading tasks. All new topics are summarized in a short recapitulation at the end of every section.

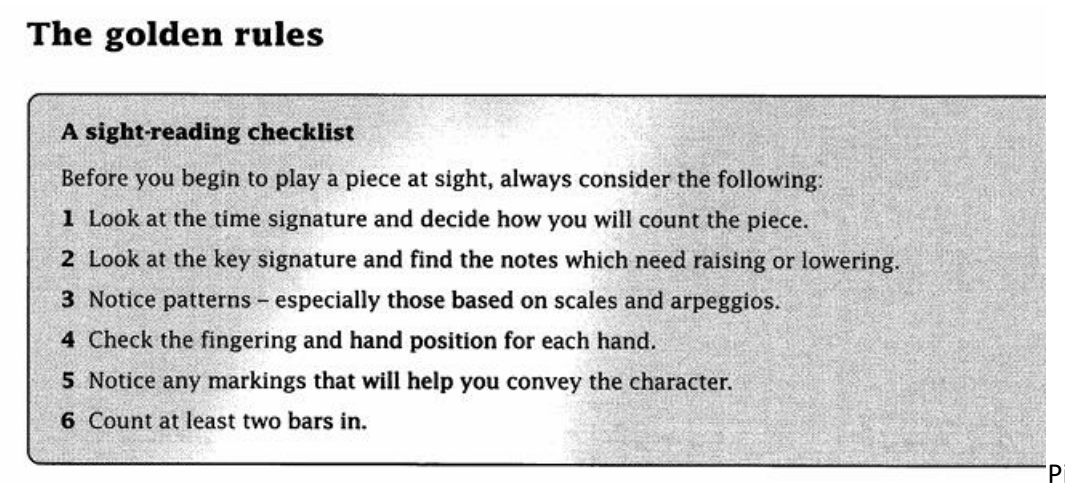


Pic.4

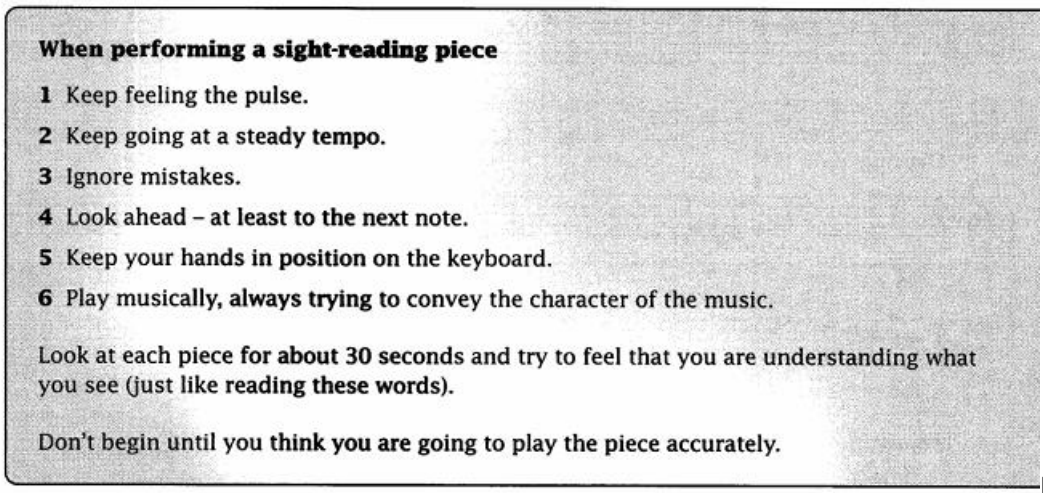
The first book called „Pre-Grade 1"is designed for children and presents the basics of music notation. Already at this early stage emphasizes Harris two main rules: *„Always count!" and „Never stop!" (Harris, 2009, p.2)* The student is asked to always count out one bar loudly and one bar in the head before starting to play the exercise. He likes musical pulsation compared to a heartbeat, keeping the music alive. The following early-stage books are devoted to playing each hand separately, then both hands together, and later in a full five-fingers position. Each section focuses on certain keys, depending on a number of accidentals, and gradually includes additional tasks, e.g.: pedaling, changing the hand position, working on

leaps, chords, understanding of expression or dynamic marks. When comes to hand-position changing, emphasizes Harris importance of a correct fingering. To decide on a suitable one, it is necessary to look for the lowest and the highest note in each hand. In some exercises is the fingering already given, in some of them is the student remained to think about it in advance and decide by himself.

Harris always encourages for proper preparation. Before every exercise he asks instructive questions that prompt the student to think about the piece in advance. *"What will you count? In what key is this piece? Which notes are affected by the key signature?" (Harris, 2009, Grade 2 p.10)* In *"Late Elementary"* stage he also presents *"The Golden rules",* universal propositions that could help the student to improve. (Pic.5, 6)



Pic.5



Pic.6

The later stages of books are dedicated to interpretation. The author deals with the query, of how to perform a piece immediately with the suitable musical expression. He formulates again several instructive questions that should be asked by every interpreter before performing: *"What is the mood? Are there important or recurring melodic or rhythmic patterns? What is the piece about? Do you understand it?" (Harris, 2008, Grade7 p.39)* Harris

encourages paying attention to clues in the score that state the character, for instance, dynamic marks, directions of melodic lines, keys, rhythmical values, etc.

The last book *"Advanced"* focuses on meter changes, phrasing, and polyphonic structures. Given materials contain polyphonic pieces like fugues, inventions, or passacaglias. Managing the last stage of the nine-book series is a good preparation to sight-read an actual piano repertoire.

"Improve your sight-reading" is, from my point of view, a very well-structured series. The difficulty increases slowly, so the student goes through every stage properly. For teachers could be very handy that everything is sorted in one place: rhythmical exercises, melodic exercises, and actual sight-reading materials. Every chapter is theoretically introduced, and the user is guided through the whole book by clear instructions. I believe that this could be very helpful to keep the student´s attention during the lesson. As teachers, we can control in the lesson if the student follows all instructions sufficiently, and in case of difficulties, help him with our professional input. I assume that with this approach the student creates his own routine in developing sight-reading skills by himself.

3. Online study tools for piano sight-reading

Sight-reading improvement requires a daily habit. The more is done, the faster it gets better. Like with any other skill, it is necessary to invest time into regular practice. As teachers, we should not only sight-read during lessons but also pay attention to student´s home preparation. Nowadays, this is easier since we can use a wide offer of sight-reading training online tools. Plenty of apps and online programs were designed to support musicians and to make learning easier. To figure out which tool fits the best to student´s needs, I would recommend starting with free trials and trying out several options. Once there is a clear preference, I would pay for the long-term subscription. Giving homework through such an App could be very beneficial since we have a better overview of students´ efforts.

A software that became quite famous recently is called "*Piano Marvel App".* The best way to use this app is with an iPad. It could be connected with a mini keyboard and actually mark the level of student´s accuracy. After the exercise is finished, gets the student a clear result and several points that reflect his feat. Pieces are taken from an actual piano repertoire. With *"The Piano Marvel App"* is even possible to track, how many hours the student practiced per day. That could be very useful for teachers to keep an eye on proper home preparation.

"Sight Reading Factory" is a sight-reading app designed for different instruments. In this app, users customize exercises by themselves. Pieces are generated by AI according to entered parameters (e.g. meter, key, level of difficulty, etc.). That can help the student to focus on one particular thing, for example, a dotted rhythm or a certain meter. This specific topic could be beforehand tried in the lesson and as homework could assigned exercises with similar parameters. The confidence to play in a new key could be gained much easier like that. It also brings a big benefit of unlimited sight-reding material. On the other hand, exercises lack variety in the matter of forms or styles (e.g. fugues or dances are not available).

"Reading Ahead App" focuses mainly on building up the habit of reading ahead. That is a common problem for the majority of sight-readers. In this app, notes disappear once they are played, and that leads the student to look at the bars in front. There are also exercises specialized to improve short-term memory. The student observes a melodic phrase just for a short moment and is supposed to play it afterward by heart. The app contains music from the actual repertoire. Besides that, it includes short technical or rhythmical exercises for daily warm-ups.

The last tool I would like to present is called *"RSM Online Sight Reading and Ear Training".* This software was designed by *"The Royal Conservatory of Music",* a musical program based in Canada. This app is devoted mainly to sight-reading exam preparation. There is a wide offer of guided exercises, individual practice, and also the "exam experience". To induce the same atmosphere as an exam, the score page appears blank first and once the timer is pressed the student has only 30 seconds to study the piece beforehand. Guided exercises stay for instructions, for instance, to circle certain aspects in the score or to clap a given rhythm. Recording of every rhythmical exercise is available in the app, which gives students an opportunity to compare and evaluate themselves. For those who prefer paper materials, *"The Royal Conservatory of Music"* also published the book series *"Four Stars Sight-reading".*

6. Conclusion

This thesis aimed to define the importance of sight-reading and discuss the lack of its education in an ordinary music curriculum. In connection with that, we pay attention to the importance of sight-reading included in the general piano lesson. Another important aspect is the way piano teachers support their students in further training. The prior focus is placed on concrete tips and exercises, that could be practiced on a daily basis. Analysis of the study book for piano sight-reading *"Improve Your Sight-reading"* by British pedagogue Paul Harris gave us an overview of a well-structured method that could be followed during lessons and that can help students to create a functional routine. It was clarified that teachers should respect the individual needs of each student and according to them adjust the difficulty level and the time placement in the lesson. It was also emphasized how significant is the home preparation. Using one of the online tools mentioned in this thesis could be a great solution to keep an eye on that as well. The most important target for every teacher should be the effort to start with sight-reading education as soon as possible. By developing all essential sub-skills at the right moment, we can raise a generation of prominent and confident pianists who would interpret music in the most natural way.

7. Resources

Literary resources:

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Harris P. (2008-9) *Improve your sight-reading – Pre-Grade 1, "Elementary", "Late elementary", "Early Intermediate", "Early advanced", "Advanced"*

London: Faber Music

Johnson, T. A. (2017) *Right@Sight, Grade 1-7*

Leipzig, Germany: Editions Peters

Baštová Š. (2019) *English piano schools for sight reading at the turn of 20th and 21st centuries*

Ostrava, Czech Republic: University of Ostrava, Faculty of Fine Arts

Vlasáková A. (2003) *"Piano pedagogy. First steps on the journey to the art of piano"*

Prague, Czech Republic: Academy of Performing Arts in Prague

Online recourses:

Smits H.T. *"Piano Lessons with Brillante Piano Duo" How to Really Improve Sight Reading | 8 action steps, 4/11 2023*

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nZnvWQr9d4E&t=388s

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Boyd K. *“The Piano Prof” 4 Apps to Help You Improve your Piano Sight Reading 12/9 2023*

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YnJc4kjK-5U&list=PLFLdL7igcaAYEJ7kyivbvW-02uaUqsaKl&index=4